

Eating with the Enemy

The first time Sulochona came to our house as a domestic help, we knew instantly that she was unlike the others who had worked for us earlier.

She hadn't come alone. Following her in a polite, awestruck procession were her elder daughter, Sitamata, holding her baby daughter in her arms; her two sons; and, finally, Mathabhangi, the youngest. They all traipsed through our verandah, drawing room, dining room, and finally entered the kitchen. In the kitchen, while her brood sat in the corners, staring wide-eyed at the house, Sulochona plopped herself on the ground and began talking non-stop about her unhappy childhood and the hardships she was having to suffer.

Sulochona Behera was a Harijan of the Ghaasi caste. Her family and her ancestors all belonged to Ghatshila, where her father used to work at the copper factory. The only child of her parents, she claimed that had fate been kinder, she could have lived like a princess. Unfortunately for her—and her mother as well—her father fell in love with another woman. He brought her home and drove his

wife out of the house. His in-laws attempted to intervene, and tried to take little Sulochona away from her father, but failed. After a while, even Sulochona's mother stopped trying to get her daughter back. She married again, leaving the poor girl to her fate.

And what a fate it was! Sulochona's stepmother was evil, her father was drunk nearly all the time, even at work, and Sulochona remained a princess-who-could-have-been.

Sulochona grew up to be a lovely girl—healthy and fair-skinned. But the abuse changed her from within, and hardened her.

Of all the friends Sulochona had in Ghatshila, she was closest to Subhadra Agarwal, a Marwari girl whose family had migrated from Haryana years earlier.

It was strange that a Ghaasi and a Marwari girl could become the best of friends. Perhaps it was their age—they were almost as old as each other. Perhaps it was their situation; Subhadra's mother—her own mother!—was almost as bad as Sulochona's stepmother.

One day, the scolding and the beatings got too much for both the girls. They ran away. But where on earth could they go? They ended up just a kilometre-and-a-half away from home, on the north bank of the Subarnarekha River, where the trucks from the factory dump boiler-ash and from where Sulochona, Subhadra and hundreds of other women came to pick boiler-ash to make gul and goitha, fuel for their kitchens.

'I want to die, friend,' Subhadra said. 'It was my misfortune that I was born.'

'I want to die, too, friend,' Sulochona said.

'What do we do? How do we die?' Subhadra asked.

'I don't know. Should we jump into the river?'

'No, no. That will not work. Both of us know how to swim. And if these women see us, they will inform our mothers and we will be in even more trouble.'

'Oh! What do we do then?' said Sulochona, and began looking around for ways to kill themselves.

'Subhadra! Look!'

'What? What?'

'Should we eat that?' Sulochona pointed to a tall shrub.

'That?' asked Subhadra. 'Is it good? Will it kill us?'

'I have heard it kills people. Its fruits and seeds are poisonous. See, even the cows don't eat it.'

'That even I have heard. But I don't know for sure. What if we don't die? I really want to die! I don't want to live anymore!'

'Let's try it.' Sulochona and Subhadra both walked up to a *Calotropis* shrub. They plucked a few of its fruits, ground them along with the seeds, and when they thought they had enough poison, prepared themselves to consume it.

'Sulochona, friend,' Subhadra said, softly, 'will we really die? What will happen after we die?'

'I don't know, friend,' Sulochona said. 'But what will happen if we don't die? Will our mothers find out?'

'Yes. And what if we go blind? Or become mute?'

'I don't want to die, friend. I don't want to die.'

Both friends threw the poison away and hugged each other. They then both cried like never before.

After they were done, Sulochona Behera and Subhadra Agarwal walked down to the Subarnarekha, washed their hands, threw water on their eyes and faces, dried themselves, made themselves presentable and, promising to stick with each other during unhappy times, walked back to their homes.

Though the girls had pledged lifelong fidelity, separation was inevitable. Subhadra got married to a Marwari from Rairangpur town in Odisha. Her husband was much older than her, but he was a good man. Sulochona wasn't that lucky. Her husband, Dinanath Behera, was as bad as her father. He, too, was a local; he worked in the copper factory, and was a drunk. Marriage might have improved Subhadra's condition, but marriage proved to be the second round of misery in Sulochana's life.

Such was Dinanath's indifference to his children that he didn't even think of names for them. Their eldest daughter was named when Subhadra came to meet Sulochona one day when she was in Ghatshila. The previous night, she had attended a satsang organized by the Marwari community. There had been a reading of the *Ramayan* at the satsang.

'You haven't named your daughter yet?' Subhadra was surprised. 'She is four years old!'

'We call her Nini,' Sulochona said indifferently.

'How can you call her Nini? Will you call her Nini all

her life?' Subhadra asked. 'Give her a proper name. Name her...er...er... Name her Sitamata!'

'Sitamata?'

'Yes, Sitamata. Bhagwan Ram's wife. I heard of her at the satsang yesterday. If you name her Sitamata, she will have the qualities of the goddess. When she grows up, she will find a good husband. She will live happily all her life.'

So Sulochona's elder daughter became Sitamata Behera.

Sulochona's younger daughter—who, too, was being called Nini—was named in an equally arbitrary fashion. She was five when she tripped and fell and opened up a gash on her head which bled so profusely that Sulochona almost fainted.

'Aamaar chhana-r matha phati gelo! Aamaar chhana-r matha bhangi gelo!' Sulochona wailed, first in her tola and then at the hospital which had been set up specially for the employees of the copper factory.

'Quiet!' the nurses scolded her. 'Will you shut up and let us do our work? Her head is not broken. It's just a gash. We will stitch it up.'

'Stitch? Oh maa go!' Sulochona beat her head with her hands and fell on to the floor.

'Take the mother out of the OT,' the doctor on duty ordered. 'Tell her that her child is fine. And is her father an employee? Why doesn't he have a medical book? Such careless people! Now what should we write as the girl's name? Ask her mother.'

'What is your daughter's name, kaki?' one of the boys

who had helped bring Sulochona's daughter to the hospital asked her.

'Matha bhangi gelo!' was all Sulochona could say.

'Matha bhangi...' Sulochona became hysterical. 'Matha bhangi... Matha bhangi... Matha bhangi...!'

'Mathabhangi,' the boy told the doctor and the nurse. 'Her name is Mathabhangi.'

'Mathabhangi? What kind of a name is that?'

'Don't ask, sir,' the nurse whispered to him. 'These people! All day they drink and have fun. What other name can they think up for their children?'

The name stuck: Mathabhangi—the one with a broken head.

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Sulochona would gather gossip from all the houses where she worked, and tell yo and jhi everything. One day, yo snapped at her: 'Sulochona, don't be so cheap! You bring us stories from all over the world. You must surely be telling our stories to the world!' That day onwards, Sulochona had started keeping a safe distance from yo, and her usual time for a gossip-related visit was in the afternoon—at 4 p.m. sharp—when yo would be working in the hospital and jhi would be taking her nap.

The clunk of the front gate alerts jhi. 'Kaal-groho ashchhe,' she mumbles, half-awake.

'Didi! O didi! Utho!' Sulochona bangs the window of the room where jhi sleeps. 'Didi! How much will you sleep? Utho! I have something to tell you. O didi!'

Jhi feigns sleep, but for how long? The only way to turn Sulochona away is to listen to what she has to say.

'Didi, you know?' Jhi, finally out of bed, is seated in the verandah on a chair, a newspaper in her hands, pretending to read, and Sulochona is at her feet. 'That Rina, she kicks her husband.'

That stirs jhi's interest. 'Which Rina?' she asks.

'That Bangali woman, didi,' Sulochona says, her eyes wide like saucers. 'She plays cricket, you know?'

'Ah, yes.'

'She kicks her husband!'

'Oh! How do you know?'

'I was working in her kitchen, didi. She played music on her 2-in-1 and began dancing. Her husband was sitting on the sofa, watching happily. I also began to watch. Then, when the song ended, she went and kicked her husband.'

'Kicked her husband? Why?'

'I don't know. Just like that. For fun, maybe. She said she often kicks her husband.'

'And her husband didn't do anything?'

'No, didi. That impotent fellow just fell on the ground and began laughing.'

'Oh!'

'I told her, "Rina, sami ke nai maarte." And she said, "What can I do, masi? This is so much fun!" Just see, didi! Had it been my husband, he would have beaten me black and blue.'

That was true. Dinanath would regularly beat Sulochona.

Dinanath had brought Mohini home soon after Mathabhangi was born. She was a Gaund—from the milkman caste—and was much younger than both Dinanath and Sulochona. Mohini used to run a desi-liquor bhati that Dinanath patronized. They fell in love, he fucked her a few times, and then brought her home as his mistress.

That was all Mohini wanted. She came from a poor family. Had she carried on selling alcohol, she would have also ended up selling her body. So, instead of being stuck in a situation where she would have to belong to many men, she felt it was better to live in the house of a man who had a regular job. It didn't matter that he was already married, that his wife was still alive, and that they had four children.

Sulochona was devastated.

'Didi, that woman is a witch! A daini! A petni!' Sulochona told jhi. 'You know, they sleep in the inner room, I sleep outside. And whole night their chowki creaks kee kee kee, and that Mohini is moaning aa aa aa. Baarbhatari! Only god knows what she does with my husband! I never moaned like that when I slept with that useless husband of mine. And our chowki too did not creak that much.'

On other days, Sulochona would be very kind to Mohini. She would tell jhi, 'Didi, you know, Mohini brought ingreji liquor and chakhna from her mother's house. Such pork! We all ate and drank, di. Me, Mathabhangi's father and Mohini. Mohini is such a good woman!'

There were days when Dinanath would savagely beat Sulochona in a drunken rage. Once done, he would drink more alcohol and then, to let off remaining steam, fuck Mohini equally savagely.

The day after, Sulochana would tell jhi, 'That bitch! That kukkur-muhi, baarbhatari Mohini! However much she might take my husband's cock, she will not have a baby. She is baanjihi! That's what she is. The way they do kee kee kee and aa aa aa, she should have had ten babies by now. But no, she will not have any babies. I will remain the only mother of my husband's children.'

If jhi would see me lurking around the kitchen, eavesdropping, she'd snap, 'Sulochona, chupp! Too much talking. Let's get some work done.'

It was hard to understand the relationship between Sulochona and Mohini. At times, Sulochona called Mohini her biggest enemy; at other times, they were the best of friends.

Mohini, for her part, understood her inferior position in the household that she was living in. She was there only for Dinanath's pleasure, while Sulochana controlled everything. She could never take Sulochona's place, she

could never have a child and, in fact, did not want to be burdened with one. Also, she wasn't even half as attractive or cultured as Sulochona. Sulochona worked in Bengali households and spoke and dressed up like the women she worked for. When Sulochona wore a starched cotton saree with a sleeveless blouse, oiled and tied her hair in a neat chignon and spoke impeccable Bengali, no one could tell that she was an ordinary, illiterate Ghaasi woman who couldn't even sign her own name. Sulochona knew how to shop for the best vegetables and how to cook a decent meal. As far as running a household was concerned, Mohini was no match for her. So she always conducted herself carefully in Sulochona's presence.

It was an uneasy arrangement, but one that worked. The state of affairs was not to last, however, for Dinanath died of liver failure.

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After Dinanath's death, Sulochona became aggressive and absolutely determined to grab control of her own life. No wonder, she also became very selfish and greedy. She ran from pillar to post to arrange for Dinanath's pension to be paid to her every month. With yo's help, she filled up forms at a local bank, learned to sign her name, and opened an account for herself. The money she earned from her work in various houses, and the pension she received, further fuelled her desires. And, if there was anything that she couldn't buy, she stole it.

Close to the tola where she lived were the quarters of the employees of the copper factory. Next to one of the houses, allotted to a Bihari family, she saw a drumstick tree laden with fruit. She knew that the family wouldn't give her any, so when people were not watching, she stole some. This went on for a day or two. One day, the lady of the house caught Sulochona red-handed.

'Stop!' the woman shouted. 'So you are the one stealing our danthas? Is this your father's tree?'

Sulochona launched her own attack, 'So, is this *your* father's tree? You Biharis! You think this is your fathers' land? This is *our* land. Don't forget, *you* all are outsiders here. I am a daughter of this land and *all* the trees here belong to us!'

Saying this, she slipped away with her loot. The Bihari woman could only stare on in amazement at this bare-facedness.

Of all the houses Sulochona worked in, ours was the only Santhal—in fact, the only Adivasi—house. The rest of the houses all belonged to Bengalis and it was working for those women which had given Sulochona her superior demeanour. Perhaps because we spoke in the language, she, like most people, thought we were Bengali too.

Once we were getting the backyard patio of our bungalow repaired. The workers that the contractor had employed were all Santhals from nearby villages. One day, jhi made tea for those workers, served them in steel cups, and asked Sulochona to collect the cups after the workers

had finished drinking and washed the cups themselves. Sulochona shrank back in horror.

'But, didi,' she told jhi, 'they are Adivasis!'

Jhi was dumbstruck. Later, after Sulochona had left, jhi laughed like she had not laughed in a long time, and so did we, for days afterwards.

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A few months after Dinanath died, Mohini went away without a word to anyone. When she returned to Ghatshila after a year or so, Sulochona could hardly recognize her. She had gained weight and was wearing an expensive saree, jewellery and make-up.

'Mohini, what happened to you?'

'I got married,' Mohini revealed coyly.

On leaving Sulochona, Mohini had gone off to Sonari in Jamshedpur to live with her cousins. There, she was introduced to Babu, a Telugu man who had lived in Jamshedpur for a very long time. Everyone said that he was a businessman.

No one knew what his full name was; everyone just called him Babu. He lived in a huge house in Adityapur, on the other side of Kharkai River, in the neighbouring Seraikella-Kharsawan district. A young cousin of Mohini's worked at a gym frequented by some of the young men who worked for Babu. They were rough, although utterly charming, fellows and Mohini's cousin was their good friend. When her cousin was invited to a puja hosted by

one of those boys, she tagged along. It was at the puja that she caught Babu's eye.

Mohini went to Babu's house—it was huge! There were rows of trucks, cars and SUVs parked outside it, which remained standing there much of the time. The man was much older than Mohini—perhaps in his fifties or his sixties. He was a widower, his children were either married off or lived elsewhere. Babu lived alone in his house with his staff—tall, young, muscular men who jumped to his every command. They counted money, held discussions in private; sometimes she saw guns in their hands, sometimes they brought a young woman or two and took them into Babu's bedroom.

Mohini might be illiterate but she knew the world enough to understand that Babu was not merely a businessman. However, he could give her the two things she craved most: money and stability. So after about two months of sleeping together, when Babu proposed marriage to Mohini, she accepted.

Babu was addicted to sex. Young, old, dark, fair, whatever the woman, he only sought the crack between their legs. Despite his age and his balding pate, he thought he was irresistible to women. He dressed up in tight, shiny trousers and colourful, printed shirts which he wore with the collars raised. He sported oversized sunglasses and wristwatches. He oiled whatever hair he had left on his scalp with strong-smelling ayurvedic oil and combed it in such a way that it covered the bald patches on his head. He

chewed paan masala, smoked, and always smelt of paan masala and sweat. Despite his age, though, Babu gave Mohini plenty of pleasure. Yet, he did not stop seeing other women. If he fucked Mohini in the afternoon, he had some other woman brought into his bedroom in the night. Those were the times when Mohini was supposed to silently stay in her own room—furnished with a television and an air-conditioner. She knew not to ask any questions. But one day, curiosity and envy got the better of her, and she asked Babu about the woman who had come to his room the previous night and had been so drunk that she had vomited outside Mohini's room.

'Who's she? Such a filthy woman!' Mohini complained.

Babu got up and dragged Mohini by her hair to her room. He threw her to the ground, stripped her, pulled out his belt, and gave her a thorough lashing.

'You will ask me questions? You know who you are? Women like you dance on my fingertips!'

That night, Babu did not have any other woman. He came to Mohini's room with food, fed her, undressed her, touched the parts where he had hit her and, when Mohini winced, he kissed and licked the welts. Babu's tongue therapy aroused Mohini. For more, he squeezed her breasts and sucked on them. Soon, Mohini was ready. He fucked her and whispered his love into her ears. 'You know how much I love you. Mohini, you are my life. The other women are nothing before you. They are all rendi. You are my wife. You know that. Why do you make me do such

things? Why do you make me angry? Hmmm... Mohini? You know I can't live without you.'

Mohini's place in Babu's life, even though she was his wife, was the same as her place in Dinanath's. In return for on-demand sex, she would receive food, a clean toilet, cold air from an air-conditioner, all-day entertainment from the TV, clothes, money, a car with a driver to go around spending all that money and the status of a wife. To her, it didn't seem like a bad deal at all.

And this was exactly what Mohini told Sulochona, leaving out the sex, the other women, the strongmen with their guns, the cigarettes, alcohol and vomit, as well as the violence.

Sulochona was impressed. On the last day of Mohini's stay in Ghatshila, as they sat together, alone, Sulochona preparing tea on her goitha chulha and Mohini stirring mustard oil from a jar of Sulochona's pickles into a baati of jhal-muri, Sulochona looked all around to check if someone was listening and said, 'Mohini, will you take my Mathabhangi with you? Maybe she can learn something there. Maybe she will see a new kind of life. You see, here she has almost nothing. I can give her nothing. Maybe your Babu can change her life, find her a good groom or something.'

Mohini froze. The oil-stained spoon slipped from her fingers and plopped into the heap of muri in the bowl. No no no. Mathabhangi? In Adityapur? In Babu's house? No. Never. What if she revealed her secret to Babu? And,

worse, what if Babu kept the young, blooming, virgin Mathabhangi and drove her out of the house?

'Er... What can I do for Mathabhangi, didi?'

Sulochona squatted before Mohini and grabbed her hands. 'You are the one who can do everything. Mohini, remember, haven't we lived liked sisters? You are Mathabhangi's aunt. No, no, you are her mother, her second mother. If you don't help Mathabhangi, who will?'

As the tea boiled on the chulha, Sulochona's insistence intensified; and, by the time the tea boiled over, the obstinate, persistent Sulochona had extracted the promise that Mohini would take Mathabhangi with her to Adityapur.

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In Adityapur, Mohini introduced Mathabhangi as 'my elder sister's daughter from Ghatshila'. Mohini, clever woman that she was, had told Babu nothing about her past. He knew that Mohini had a widowed sister, Sulochona, but nothing more.

In Ghatshila, Sulochona was unable to contain her happiness. She came rushing over to our house soon after she had seen off Mohini and Mathabhangi at the station early in the morning.

'Didi! Didi!'

Jhi was making tea at that time.

'You know, didi.' Sulochona started speaking as jhi strained the tea into the cup that had been marked for

Sulochona. 'I sent Mathabhangi with Mohini to live in Babu's house in Adityapur. She will be soooo happy!'

Jhi, shocked, dropped the saucepan. The steel cup clanged on to the kitchen floor.

'What happened, didi?' Sulochona came rushing to her. 'Are you hurt? You should have been careful.'

'Careful?' Jhi turned towards Sulochona in anger. 'You are asking me to be careful, you stupid woman? *You* should have been careful, boka-chodi!'

'Di-di!' Sulochona stared at jhi, puzzled.

'Have you gone out of your mind?' Jhi mustered a deep breath and hissed at Sulochona.

'Didi, I thought—'

'Sulochona, listen.' Jhi composed herself, picked up the cup and placed it on the counter, and turned towards Sulochona. 'Do you know this man? This Babu?'

Sulochona shook her head.

'This Mohini, who was just your soutin who left once your husband died, and who went ahead and married some rich man she just met somewhere, how could you, just how could you send your young daughter with such a woman to live in the house of a strange man in a strange place?'

For a long time, Sulochona could not speak. Jhi kept staring at her in anger.

'Didi,' Sulochona said finally, not meeting jhi's eyes, 'I thought Mathabhangi will be happy there. She will have good food to eat and good clothes to wear. Both her brothers

are married. They will not look after her. I have nothing. What will I give her? So I—'

Jhi sighed. 'Sulochona, what else do you want to give your daughter? Aren't you giving her enough food, enough clothes? Wasn't she happy here? In your own house? Her father's house? You know what kind of woman Mohini is, don't you? You yourself told me what she did with your husband. And you thought you could trust this woman with your daughter?'

Sulochona eased herself slowly on to the ground, lost in thought. For a long time she said nothing. Jhi cleaned the saucepan and started boiling water to make tea again.

'Whatever is in her fate,' Sulochona said softly. 'I just want her to see the world, learn new things. Whatever bhogobaan has planned for her, who can deny that?'

Jhi shook her head in defeat. 'Fine. Now get up and wash your cup. Drink some tea, eat those two parathas. Then we'll begin work. I really hope you get to learn new lessons.'

In the evening, jhi told the story to yo.

'Don't ever advise that woman,' yo said angrily. 'I know this Sulochona very well. She is so greedy, so unthinking, she can sell herself. Have you seen her arrogance? The way she talks about Adivasis! And even about the people of her own caste! She thinks herself a Bengali. She thinks she is smarter than everyone. You would think that with the sad childhood that she has had, she would learn some lessons in kindness and sensible behaviour. But no. As long as she

doesn't learn a hard lesson, she will never learn. Let her send her children to whichever place she pleases. It is her own life. It is useless telling her sensible things. Don't ever mention Mohini or Mathabhangi to her again.'

That was it. Jhi did not ask after Mathabhangi after that. But she did notice that Sulochona—who would otherwise never stop jabbering—would be lost in her own thoughts.

In Adityapur, Babu treated Mohini and Mathabhangi to delicious food and beautiful clothes. He took them in his car to see Jamshedpur. They went to the Jubilee Park, saw a movie at Payal Talkies, ate dosas and street food in Bistupur. Mathabhangi was very happy. In just four days, she had learnt to operate the air conditioner and the television. Mohini was relieved. She saw that Mathabhangi hadn't mentioned her mother and family to Babu. Even Babu wasn't interested in knowing about Mohini's 'elder sister'. He seemed keen only on entertaining Mathabhangi.

'Masi, will you buy me the ghaghri-chunri we saw in that shop?' Mathabhangi asked Mohini on one of their outings.

'Sure,' Babu said. 'Why not?'

At the end of the fifth day, Babu brought Mathabhangi her ghaghri-chunri. He went straight into Mathabhangi's room and latched the door from within.

'Your ghaghri-chunri, lovely girl.' He sat on Mathabhangi's bed and stroked her cheeks.

Mathabhangi's happiness turned to alarm. She couldn't speak a word.

'Come on, wear it,' Babu ordered, reeking of alcohol and lust.

Mathabhangi froze.

'Yes, wear it,' Babu insisted. 'Take off this salwar-kameez.' He pulled away Mathabhangi's dupatta. 'What old clothes you're wearing! I want to see you in your new dress.'

Mathabhangi was so terrified that she couldn't resist, she couldn't move even a limb. Babu slid his hands inside her kameez and squeezed her budding breasts. He then untied the drawstring of her salwar and pulled it down. Mathabhangi was naked waist downwards. He then took off his shirt and stood bare-chested before the terrified teenager.

'Come on, come to me.' He kissed her on the lips, rubbed his face against her, nuzzled her neck. Mathabhangi's eyes welled up with tears of fear and helplessness.

'What happened?' he asked her, rubbing her vagina. 'Why are you crying? My girl, I love you. Look, such a lovely dress I have brought for you. Ghaghri-chunri. You wanted this, didn't you?' He then made Mathabhangi lie on the bed and raised the hem of her kameez. She was now fully exposed. He took off his pants and climbed over her.

Mathabhangi gathered whatever courage and strength she had and shouted, 'Ma! Masi!'

'What ma masi?' Babu laughed, and clasped Mathabhangi's left hand over his erect penis. 'Saali bhosri! Why am I keeping you in this house? Why am I feeding you, buying you things? And why did your mother send you here in the first place? To eat free food?'

Mathabhangi's tears flowed freely now. But her voice was still stuck in her throat.

'Hold this, nicely,' Babu tightened Mathabhangi's grip over his penis. 'Have you seen anything like this? Isn't this good? Your masi loves it very much. You will love it too.' He kissed her on the lips again.

At that very moment, there was a loud hammering on the door.

'Please, please, don't do anything to her!'

It was Mohini. She had somehow caught wind of what Babu was up to.

'Please, Babu-ji, please. Leave her. Leave that girl. She is just a child. Her mother trusted me enough to bring her here. Please, leave her.'

Babu paid no heed. He sucked on Mathabhangi's lips.

'Babu-ji, leave that girl! I will bring you whichever girl you please. I will do anything for you. Anything you say. Please, leave that girl.'

Babu started stroking Mathabhangi's vagina and played with her pubic hair as she tried to clasp her thighs together.

'Rendi!' Babu hissed in anger. 'Unclasp your thighs, madarchod! Spread them!' He prised open her thighs and put his finger into her vagina. 'I know how to prepare you, madarchod!'

Mathabhangi broke down at this point. 'Masi!' she screamed. And, in fright, she lost control of her bladder and urinated all over Babu's hand.

'Madarchod!' Babu rose in anger as Mathabhangi's warm urine splashed on his skin. 'Spoiled my mood!' He slapped Mathabhangi hard on her face. Her head turned to one side and she began sobbing in fits.

Babu opened the door. Mohini was standing there like a mad woman, her hair open, her tears washing away every bit of make-up on her face.

Babu dragged Mohini into the room and stomped out. Seconds later, realizing that he was naked, he returned to Mathabhangi's room, took her dupatta, tied it around his waist, and stomped out again. By this time, Mohini was already holding Mathabhangi's trembling body in her arms.

'Take her away! I don't want her in this house! Take her away or I will sell her in the market and have her fucked every day!' Babu screamed as he left the room.

Very early the next morning, Mohini dragged Mathabhangi to Tatanagar Railway Station, boarded the passenger train to Ghatshila, and took the abused girl home.

'Mohini, leave,' Sulochona said as Mohini, weeping profusely, told her the entire story. 'Before I cut your throat with my bottin, leave!'

That was the last Sulochona saw of Mohini—till she broke bread with her enemies six years later.

'Didi, you were right,' Sulochona wept very bitterly that day before jhi. 'I should have never, never trusted Mohini. After what she did to my life and my husband, how could I trust her with my Mathabhangi?'

'Sulochona, stop crying. Nothing has happened to your Mathabhangi, right? She is all right, isn't she? That Babu just forced herself upon her. He didn't actually do anything. Did he?'

'How will I know that, didi?' Sulochona broke into tears again. 'Mohini said that nothing happened. But how will I know if she was speaking the truth?'

'Didn't you ask Mathabhangi?' Jhi was getting annoyed. 'Why do you have to ask the entire world when you can get answers from your own daughter?'

'What will Mathabhangi know, didi? She is such a foolish girl!'

'Mathabhangi is not foolish, *you* are foolish! She is just a child. You are her mother, you pushed her into that quicksand, and you have the nerves to call her foolish? *You* are foolish! The most foolish woman in this world!'

Sulochona kept staring at jhi's angry face for a few seconds. Then she broke into tears once more.

'Yes, didi. You are right. I am foolish. The most foolish woman in this world. I don't know what will happen to my daughter now. Who will marry her? Her life has been spoilt.'

From that day onwards, Sulochona remained obsessed with the incident every moment. She started muttering to

herself: 'That Babu did behujjat to my daughter. And that Mohini. They are my enemies.' At times, she would cry: 'My Mathabhangi! What will happen to her?'

And while time did nothing to heal Sulochona's wounded trust, it transformed Mathabhangi into a beauty. Only a few years after the incident with Babu, she became a completely different person. Her body and mind both changed. She was brimming with possibilities. And she had fallen in love.

Sitamata's husband had a younger brother. His name was Chunu. He was of the same age as Mathabhangi and worked as a driver. He went to a number of places with the trucks and vans he drove, and his travels had given him a ruggedly handsome look. During Mathabhangi's several visits to the house of her elder sister's in-laws, Chunu and she fell in love with one another. Everyone seemed to know about their affair, but Sulochona had been so blinded by her obsession that she failed to see the flames of passion which were flaring right under her own nose.

One morning, Mathabhangi asked Sulochona permission to visit the Rankini Mandir at Jadugora with her friends. Sulochona let her go, asking her to return early.

'Don't worry, ma,' Mathabhangi replied playfully. 'I have someone to look after me.'

Sulochona couldn't understand what she was saying.

That afternoon, when Mathabhangi returned from the mandir, she wasn't alone; she had brought Chunu along.

He was dressed in a white kurta-pyjama while Mathabhangi wore a shiny saree and some jewellery. They both had marigold garlands around their necks and marigold petals were strewn all over their heads and clothes. Chunu had a long sindoor tika drawn on his forehead. Mathabhangi had a bright red ridge of sindoor in the parting of her hair just above her forehead. They were both beaming in happiness. They fell at Sulochona's feet together.

'Ma, bless us,' Mathabhangi said excitedly. 'We got married.'

Sulochona, with great reluctance, blessed the newlyweds.

The next day Sulochona hugged jhi and sobbed uncontrollably. 'Didi, I am dead!' she kept saying.

'My daughter,' she said, 'she has married that good-for-nothing Chunu.'

'Sulochona, I think that's quite fine.' Jhi didn't know what else to say. 'Chunu and Mathabhangi like each other. And, at least that boy has a job. He doesn't sit idle like other friends and cousins of his. He will look after your daughter very well.'

Sulochona looked indignant. 'But, didi, he used to go around with all those girls. Bloody driver! What else will he know?'

Jhi really had nothing to say now. All the years that Sulochona had worked at our house, half of jhi's time was spent—jhi preferred to call it wasted—listening to Sulochona's sad stories and being an Agony Aunt to her.

'Sulochona, we have to clean the ceilings today. Please, bring the long broom,' jhi said, and escaped.

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Our bungalow had two outhouses. One we had given over to a Karwa couple. Karwa are Harijan, from the community called Methor. Traditionally, the Methor have worked as sweepers. The Karwa woman was the daughter of a safai karmachari at the hospital run by the copper company where yo was a doctor. The Karwa woman's husband was from Rairangpur, a small, quiet town in Odisha. So, when he came to live in the Harijan Basti in Ghatshila where his in-laws lived, he found the noise in the colony, the music systems and televisions that played all the time, and the ceaseless chatter and the general nonchalance of the youth too much to bear. So he asked his father-in-law to arrange a quiet house for his family away from the Harijan Basti.

The father-in-law, a trusted acquaintance of yo's, asked her, and yo, who knew the family well, readily agreed.

The Karwa man looked after our garden and did odd jobs around the house while the woman worked in our house whenever Sulochona took the day off.

A few months after Mathabhangi's elopement, Sulochona came crying to jhi. 'All men are the same. Useless. Look at my sons. They say they can't keep me in that house. Their father's house.' Jhi and yo really had no choice. Sulochona had worked with us for so many years that we had to help her. Yo allowed Sulochona to live in our other outhouse.

Soon after she had installed herself in her new quarters, Sulochona said to jhi, 'Didi, I am so happy that I have come to live with you all. Now I can spend more time with you.' Jhi was grinding ginger on a sil-lodha. And while she could have thrown the large grindstone at Sulochona's head, she somehow controlled herself. She needed Sulochona, after all.

Some days after Sulochona had moved in, the Karwa woman told jhi: 'Didi, a strange woman has come to stay with kaki.'

Lately, Sulochona had become very secretive. She would not talk much and would run back to her outhouse as soon as she finished work. Jhi had already been getting suspicious.

'Which woman?' jhi asked. 'What does she look like?'

'She is dark, didi. And she was wearing a saree that looked costly. When she first arrived, she had come to our house, asking which one Sulochona's is. Now that she is living with kaki, she hardly comes out. They stay inside all the time.'

Jhi understood.

'You go,' she told the Karwa woman. 'I will talk to Sulochona.'

The following morning, when Sulochona came to work, jhi asked her: 'Sulochona, I hear you are hiding a thief in your house. Who is she?'

Sulochona froze. 'Didi, you know?'

'Yes, I know. Tell me, what is Mohini doing here?'

'Didi, shhhh...shhhh... Not so loud! People might hear.'

'Why not so loud? You think you can act smart with us? Tell me, what is Mohini doing in your house?'

What Sulochona revealed, shocked jhi.

Mohini had had a fight with Babu. Sulochona didn't know the details—Mohini, clever woman, hadn't told Sulochona all that. What Mohini did tell Sulochona was that she had thirty-thousand rupees which she had stolen from Babu's safe. Those thirty-thousand rupees were Mohini's most precious possession at the moment, and she had come to Ghatshila, to Sulochona, to keep herself and the money safe. She had promised Sulochona a share. And Sulochona—greedy, foolish woman!—had forgotten the humiliation and near-tragedy inflicted on her by Mohini and had given her sanctuary.

'Sulochona, when will you learn?' Jhi was aghast.

'Why? What happened, didi?' Sulochona was impudent enough to ask.

'What happened? That woman nearly endangered your daughter's life, and you ask what happened? You forgot everything? All that happened six years ago?'

Sulochona stayed silent for a long time and then said cautiously, 'Didi, who will I live for? That daughter of mine, she too has left me and gone. My sons don't look after me. So I came to stay in your house. What more is left of my life? If Mohini brings me something to look out for—'

'Sulochona, jump into the Subarnarekha and drown yourself' jhi snapped. 'People like you don't deserve to live.'

Such things you are saying about your daughter! Your daughter didn't leave you, she married a boy she loved. She lives with her in-laws. Tell me, weren't you worried about who would marry Mathabhangi after that incident? And Mohini? *She's* a friend all of a sudden! She brings some money and you forget what happened to your daughter. What kind of a person are you?

'Didi, what will I—'

'Shut up! That outhouse you're living in, and where you're hiding that Mohini, you don't own it. If something bad happens there, if that Babu comes and does anything, remember, we'll report all of you to the police. This is Ghatshila, not Adityapur.'

Sulochona did not come to work the next day. When jhi went out to call her from the outhouse, she found the door locked from the outside. So she called the Karwa woman to do the chores.

'Didi, you know,' the Karwa woman said to jhi as she was mopping the floor, 'a man came in a car yesterday.'

Jhi was all ears. 'Which man?' she asked.

'I don't know, didi. But he was dark and huge. He was asking for kaki. He asked, "Where does Sulochona-ji live?"'

'Sulochona-ji!' jhi mocked 'I know who this man is. He is that Mohini's husband. You know Mohini? The woman who's living with Sulochona. Her soutin! She went and married that animal. That man is a criminal! And this Sulochona is an idiot!'

'Didi, I was very scared.' The Karwa woman stood up.

'I didn't know what to say. I only said I didn't know where kaki was.'

'Don't be scared,' jhi said hotly. 'That fellow is a bad man. He deserves to be whipped. Or, worse, he deserves to have his penis cut off. If anything happens, just shout out for us. We will not leave that man alive.'

That evening jhi told yo about Babu's visit. Yo was very angry. 'Such an idiot this Sulochona is!' yo said. 'If something happens in our outhouse I will not let this Sulochona, or Mohini and her husband live in peace.'

The next day, too, Sulochona did not come to work. The Karwa woman said that her outhouse was locked. All day, jhi and the Karwa woman took turns to see if any car came to Sulochona's quarter. The problem was, however, that the Karwa woman could not tell one car from the other.

That evening jhi heard a car being parked near the outhouse, but it was dark and the car was parked in such a way that it couldn't be seen. Also, jhi noticed light in Sulochona's outhouse. She called yo.

'Wait,' yo said. 'Let's see what they do. If they're up to some mischief, they've had it.'

Contrary to our expectations, nothing untoward happened.

The next morning, sharp at 6, jhi was cleaning the kitchen when Sulochona arrived, looking very pleased with herself.

'Sulochona?' jhi asked. 'Where were you these two days?'

'Didi, didi.' Sulochona was breathless with happiness and excitement. 'You know what happened?'

'What?' Jhi feigned indifference, but she was curious.

'Mohini and Babu have reconciled.'

'What?'

~

Sulochona and Mohini knew Babu was after them. The Karwa woman had told them of Babu's arrival. So Mohini packed the thirty-thousand rupees in an innocuous-looking grocery bag, Sulochona locked her quarters, and off they went all over Ghatshila, from one corner of the town to the other, just loitering around, hiding themselves from Babu. But Babu was clever. He found them, made them sit in his car, and brought them to Sulochona's quarters.

'Mohini, you know I can't live without you. Why did you leave me?' he said to Mohini. After some other such sweet declarations of love, Mohini became Babu's again.

'This is the first time I am meeting Sulochona-ji,' he said to Mohini. 'Sulochona-ji, you are very beautiful,' he told her. He then turned to Mohini and said, 'You should learn something from your elder sister.' With this, Sulochona, too, fell for his charms.

'Let's celebrate,' Babu proposed. They went to the market and bought mutton, a full bottle of Bagpiper whisky, and chilled soda. Sulochona said that she didn't have proper glasses to drink alcohol. So Babu bought her an expensive set of glass tumblers. 'This is for you, Sulochona-ji. For your special occasions.'

Mohini cooked mutton and rice, the three ate and drank. Sulochona slept on a mat in the verandah of her outhouse, while Mohini and Babu slept on Sulochona's chowki. Sulochona heard them talking to each other and kissing. Then Mohini began moaning, and Babu whispered to her, 'Silent, silent, your didi will hear us.' Sulochona drifted off to sleep.

They got up early the next morning, Babu thrust five thousand rupees into Sulochona's hands, thanked her for her hospitality and large-heartedness, got into his Tata Indica with Mohini, and drove off to Adityapur.

'He is such a charming man, didi,' Sulochona said dreamily as jhi heard her out in disgust. 'Mohini is such a lucky woman. She is—'

'That's enough, Sulochona. Pick up the pipe and the jhadu and wash the verandah. It's getting late.'